

replicate themselves on floppies or hard disks—like mailing themselves to all your address book contacts, for instance—it is still a good idea to scan a floppy (when you must use one) for viruses after inserting it, if you haven't enabled real-time scanning in your anti-virus program. In fact, not enabling it is in itself a bad idea! Take the same precaution with CDs and DVDs as well.

The same precaution holds if you are opening or copying files from a hard disk you plugged in, or from an external storage device.

An oft-repeated tip is to avoid opening a suspicious-looking file. So just what does “suspicious” mean? Many a time, viruses disguise themselves to look like a common file type, such as using an MS Word icon to look like a Word document. The extension will be something like .doc.exe. Note that the “.doc” in the file name is not its true extension, but the “.exe” is (the characters following the last dot are the real extension of a file). So you can have “tech.abc.xyz.123.doc”, and its true extension is .doc. Now why would a file try and look like what it actually is not? Only to fool you into thinking it's a safe file and make you open it—this is what you need to be wary about.

When accessing files from a CD or external device, enable showing of extensions in Windows Explorer by going to **Tools > Folder Options > View**. Here, uncheck “Hide extensions for known file types”. Then if you come across a file with a .jpg.exe, .doc.exe etc. extensions, avoid opening them. This holds good not only for accessing data from devices other than your hard disk, but also when you download a file from the Internet or check your mail for attachments.

Avoid downloading files with the following extensions if you are not absolutely sure that it is a file you need: EXE, ZIP, SCR, PIC, BAT, PIF, VBS.